

The Khalistan Manifesto

****By Ekonkar Singh****

A product of Neo Khalsa

*Originally written in September 2023. Author's note, September 2026: this was written when I was 24 and was only a first draft. Many of my views have since evolved. Neo Khalsa supports Sikh sovereignty but is opposed to Khalistan as the movement has come to be today.

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1. Road to Sovereignty

> *"Degh for the friends, Tegh for the foes, Victory for all."*

The road to Khalistan is paved with the blood of martyrs, innocents, and enemies. The idea of sovereignty did not come from a few individuals. It was built by the founders of the Sikh panth, from Guru Nanak Dev Ji to Guru Gobind Singh Ji. The Khalsa is the expression of sovereignty at every scale: in the individual, in the collective panth, and in service to all of humanity. It is a body that looks after the interests of everyone, not only its own. The Khalsa was born into a society ruled by both Mughal and Hindu powers and scarred by their injustices. It was a society that stood by while children were bricked alive, and those were the conditions in which the Khalsa bloomed.

A Taste of Sovereignty

The Khalsa is therefore not merely a religion with a distinctive appearance, a habit of carrying weapons, and a tradition of prayer. Its desire for self-determination reaches back to the sixth Guru, Guru Hargobind. When the emperor forbade his subjects to keep the instruments of power, such as war drums, weapons, and standing armies, the Guru openly defied him and adopted all of them. The Gurus also established domains and havens where the Sikh people could live and thrive. But when the last Guru had his lands seized, his family killed, and his people under constant siege, sovereign space had to be claimed and marked with real boundaries. This was the work of Banda Singh Bahadur, whom Guru Gobind Singh commissioned to deliver justice and who gave the Sikhs their first territory and their first taste of statehood.

The First Sikh State

Banda Singh Bahadur minted coins and defined the lands of what can be considered the first Sikh-governed territory in history. After his capture and execution, however, the Sikhs were driven into inhospitable country and forced to scratch out a living from bare rock. In this "jungle era," scattered much like the modern diaspora, their thirst for sovereignty never faded. From that period came the Misl era, which culminated in the Sikh Empire under Maharaja Ranjit Singh.

The British Era

Guru Gobind Singh lived until 1708. In the century that followed his death, the Sikhs repeatedly fought for self-rule and eventually established it. That rule ended under the British after two Anglo-Sikh wars, but the desire for sovereignty endured through Sikh freedom fighters and numerous rebellions. It came to a head in 1947, when British India was divided and Sikh leaders were given assurances of autonomy and safeguards. Those assurances came with promises of good treatment and unity among dharmic brothers. The promises were short-lived. From the first day of Indian independence, Sikh sovereignty has been soaked in blood, a nightmare waiting to be woken from.

Late Twentieth-Century India

Through the 1980s the movement for Sikh autonomy reached its height, led by figures who campaigned for greater self-governance. A government bent on consolidating its own power refused them. Whatever one thinks of that era, which is marred by controversy both good and bad, no one can deny that Sikhs sought a separate state through revolution after the attack on the Golden Temple. That desire was not conjured overnight. It has a history of three hundred years.

A Sikh does not owe sovereignty to any government. A Sikh owes it to the one who granted it in the first place, which is God. Every human being has the right to determine their own destiny, and a Sikh has the additional duty to keep that sovereignty intact, especially after seeing, again and again, that those who rule do not hold Sikh interests in their vision. The Gurus gave Sikhs a philosophy for understanding themselves as inwardly free and outwardly sovereign, and as seen by the world. The Khalsa does not seek to impose its will on others. It seeks harmony through its own ethos of *degh, tegh, fateh*.

The Gall

Sikh sovereignty is a long inheritance, and it is not grounded in abstract speculation of the kind found in Western philosophy. It is a response to humanity's repeated failure to deliver degh, tegh, and fateh to its people. The Khalsa has done a great deal for every other party and very little for itself. Self-determination may not be the foundation of many people's worldview, but it is the foundation of the Khalsa's, a right given by God. If the Khalsa had cared about the world's approval, it would never have existed.

Why should Sikhs be content to live in societies that do not share their fundamental values of truth and dignity? Those societies promise utopias and deliver nightmares. The borders that confine the Khalsa today are younger than many of the people living inside them. If Indian independence showed anything, it is that these lines are arbitrary and can be drawn on the whim of a few.

So consider the history, the martyrs, and the philosophy. The desire for self-rule is so deeply part of the Sikh identity that it runs through

most of the community's recorded history. Lay all of that on the table, and then tell the Khalsa it is foolish to aspire to such heights.

2. Dharmic Unity

> *Jab lag Khalsa rahe niara*

> "So long as the Khalsa retains its distinct identity"

The Khalsa is a distinct body that draws on the combined spiritual wisdom of ten living Gurus, Bhagats from many faiths, Indic chronicles, and world history. It is more than a reaction to injustice. It offers a remedy for many of the world's ills, with guidance on everything from the conduct of the poor to the rules of war. The Khalsa has never claimed superiority, and it does not hold a monopoly on truth. Truth exists whether or not the Khalsa does. It is like a mathematical equation that belongs to no one and can be discovered by anyone.

Between Two Traditions

Sikhi emerged where two great religious streams met on the Indian subcontinent: the Abrahamic traditions of the West, which include Judaism, Christianity, and Islam, and the Dharmic traditions of the East, which include Hinduism and Buddhism. Sikhi draws on both and shares commonalities with each, because no one holds a monopoly on truth. Truth can be reached through spiritual insight and sometimes through the methods of science. When Guru Nanak wrote in the Japji Sahib of thousands of worlds and universes, he did so without a telescope. Science later confirmed what his spiritual insight had already seen. Truth can be reached by many roads, and Sikhi is one of them. It delivers truths about the human condition and refines the moral and ethical insights of those who came before.

The Theocratic Question

Sikhs have one of the strongest records of any spiritual tradition in helping those in need, friend and foe alike. They have sacrificed a great deal to protect their own right to practice and the right of others to practice theirs. This matters because of how theocracy is viewed today. Many theocracies have failed badly, using the authority of God to serve the will of rulers or bending faith to impose that will on others. Truth can be corrupted and used to oppress.

The Khalsa answers this with a principle of self-sacrifice: it holds that one should be willing to give up one's own life before harming another. The Guru Granth Sahib, the eternal Guru in book form, is divine poetry. It is not a legal code, and it does not lay out how to build law and order. The Sikh tradition has no clergy standing between the individual and God, and no scripture that dictates legislation. The text itself therefore leaves the work of governance to the community, which must build its laws through deliberation and accountability. A Sikh state should be shaped by its institutions and not by clerical decree.

Learning from Theocratic Experiments

History offers examples across the whole spectrum. Tibet, governed by Buddhist clergy and now a government in exile, flourished for a very long time, but it never developed the principle of self-defense and was overrun by China. Premodern Japan blended Shinto and Buddhism and produced a samurai class steeped in Buddhist practice, yet it still went through long periods of intense warfare. No tradition has a clean record. What decides the outcome is how power is structured and checked. The Khalsa's own experience is limited. It had one brief period in power, under Maharaja Ranjit Singh, when an aristocratic republic evolved into a monarchy with a religious character. The lesson is that a Sikh state needs strong checks on power, and the political structure proposed below is built around them.

The "Fundamentalist Ethno-State" Claim

Critics often claim that Khalistan would be a fundamentalist ethno-state. The claim does not hold up on either count.

**On fundamentalism:* Critics tend to treat Sikhi as the same sort of thing as legal-religious systems like Sharia or Wahhabism. The comparison fails because the Guru Granth Sahib is devotional poetry in praise of God and cannot be read as a legal code. It offers no basis for repressive rule. What has actually grown from it is seva, the tradition of selfless service, which any visitor to any Gurdwara in the world can see: people of every background can receive a free meal and a safe place to rest.

**On ethnicity:* Are Sikhs a single ethnicity? Visit New Mexico and you will meet Caucasian Sikhs; travel across India and you will meet Sikhs of entirely different backgrounds. Sikhi is open to everyone, so a Sikh homeland would be open to everyone. A Khalistan covering the old, united Punjab, both east and west, would include people of many ethnicities and religions, and all of them would have a home and the chance at the best life possible. The "ethno-state" label is as inaccurate as saying Sikhi is only for people over six feet tall.

Practicing Sikhs who wear the kirpan are increasingly scrutinized, in the West and in India, which is supposedly their homeland. A state founded on Sikh principles should be a place where that identity is safe.

On the Limits of Western Models

Western political thought has real achievements, and this manifesto draws on several of them. It also has a weakness the Sikh tradition has addressed differently. Western societies have often achieved stability and prosperity by relying on an underclass: ancient Athens had slavery, and many later states built their wealth on the labor of people denied rights. Equality was extended gradually, over centuries. Guru Nanak taught it as a founding principle from the outset, and it has been central to Sikhi ever since.

Modern Western ethics also often rests on the principle of avoiding harm to others and treating others as one would wish to be treated. This is a good foundation. The Khalsa ethos adds something to it: being good is hard, sometimes costing everything, and it must be done because it is right, whether or not the law requires it.

On Slavery and Bondage

Sikhs have rejected all forms of bondage of human beings, in the East and the West alike. Physically, Sikhs have never practiced the enslavement of people. They also reject the caste system, which boxes people into fixed social roles. Mentally, Sikhi offers the practices of **kirat karo** (earning an honest living) and **vand ke chakko** (sharing with the community) as a way to uplift individuals and their communities. Spiritually, it abolishes gatekeepers: the Guru Granth Sahib is open to all, written in a script that is easy to learn, and anyone of any faith can read it and take wisdom from it.

None of this makes Sikhi superior to other faiths, which share many of the same truths. The point is that the foundational principles of Sikhi can support a harmonious society that cares for those at the bottom. It does not promise riches for everyone. It holds that living honestly and doing right, even when it is hard, can produce a balanced society that is neither fundamentalist nor oppressive. For that to work, a Sikh state needs a well-balanced political structure, and what follows is a proposal for one.

3. Political Structure

> **Daya, Dharam, Himmat, Mohkam, Sahib: the Panj**

History has produced many political systems, with disastrous failures and great successes alike. Monarchies and communist regimes have often failed badly, and republics have generally done better. The system proposed here combines the strongest features of the most successful systems and rests on dharmic values. It draws on the Sarbat Khalsa, the aristocratic republic that served the Sikhs well in times of crisis.

A good system, in my judgment, reduces the opportunity for corruption and keeps power balanced so that no single person or group can hold it hostage. It lets anyone who wants a voice be heard. It also avoids bloated bureaucracy, which slows decisions through gridlock or allows them to be slipped through unnoticed.

I do not believe in democracy as practiced in the modern West. Democracy has been criticized since the time of the Greeks. Seats of power are so sought after that more effort goes into winning office than into serving the people, and constant campaigning and workarounds for personal gain weaken these systems. Socrates compared democracy to a ship whose crew chooses the most popular person to steer instead of the one who understands navigation. He also described the problem of the candy seller

and the doctor: a candidate who tells sweet lies can easily defeat a doctor who tells hard truths. The ancient world saw these flaws, and modern democracies have not fully fixed them.

The Triarchy

I propose a blend of three systems: an oligarchy, a theological autocracy, and a democracy. Politicians are not elected directly. This is where the dharmic lens comes in.

In Sikh tradition, Sikhs have organized themselves into bands called *jathas*, each led by a *jathedar*, who is its principal decision-maker. During the Misl era, the Sikhs were divided into misls, which were jathas, and members were free to join whichever one they chose and to change at will. No one was forced into allegiance. This gave rise to the Sarbat Khalsa, in which the leader of each misl met with the others to represent his group and make collective decisions.

The Sarbat Khalsa

In a modern setting, the same principle applies. Each citizen of Khalistan chooses to join a jatha that stands for what they believe, such as more spending on social services, less on the military, or a particular *rehat maryada*. Every member adds strength and influence to the jatha in parliament, the Sarbat Khalsa.

The **Senate** is modeled on an oligarchy. Each Senate seat belongs to the jathedar of a jatha with at least 15,000 members, and for every 15,000 members the jathedar gets 5 votes in the Sarbat Khalsa. Each jatha chooses its own jathedar by whatever method its members prefer: inherited tradition, a vote, or merit and achievement.

The **Takht** is the democratic house. It has more seats and a lower threshold: a jatha of 500 members can win a seat and a vote for its jathedar. If all seats are filled, the jatha with the fewest members loses its seat to a larger newcomer. With 500 seats, for example, a new jatha of 600 members would displace the 500th-ranked jatha.

The Senate and the Takht

The Senate can never initiate or oversee financial or economic policy. This prevents a small group from skimming money or benefiting from self-serving economic policy. The Takht holds one vote per jathedar and has much more freedom to act, but without overwhelming influence. Each house can correct the other: if the Senate is corrupt, the Takht can override it by collective vote, and the reverse is also true.

Any member of the Takht can propose a bill, motion, law, or policy. For it to be reviewed by the Takht, however, the Senate must first approve it by majority. The Takht can pass legislation without the Senate, but the Senate cannot act alone and must be in agreement with the Takht for anything to become law.

The Theocratic Autocracy

The third element, the theological autocracy, sits atop these two and carries the distinctly Sikh element. It has eleven members. At the base are the jathedars of the five Sikh Takhts: Kesgarh Sahib, Damdama Sahib, Hazur Sahib, Patna Sahib, and Akal Takht Sahib. (The Akal Takht Sahib seat relates more directly to Harmandir Sahib, which I will return to later.) These five oversee theological matters and the direct administration of their holy places, and each has one vote in the Sarbat Khalsa.

Above them are the Panj Pyare, five members of the Khalsa with military backgrounds who are prepared to lead the Sikhs in war and who administer Amrit, baptizing new Sikhs. Above all of them stands the Supreme Jathedar, the leader of the whole Khalsa in political, temporal, and spiritual terms. The Supreme Jathedar can declare war and veto any legislation. The position is held for life unless all three other branches vote by majority to remove the holder. Only the Panj Pyare must be male, because they administer Amrit according to the Sikh rehat. All other positions are open to women.

The members of the theocratic autocracy are chosen collectively by the jathedars of the Sarbat Khalsa, from among their own number or from outside. One of the Sarbat Khalsa's main tasks is to vote in a cabinet to run the ordinary business of government, with ministers of finance, transportation, and so on. Because the Supreme Jathedar is a figure much like a pope, he or she does not represent Khalistan to other world leaders. That role belongs to the Prime Minister, chosen by the entire Sarbat Khalsa for a two-year term, renewable or replaceable.

For Non-Sikhs

Non-Sikhs, including Hindus, Muslims, and Christians, have the same options as everyone else, with one limit: they cannot sit in the theocratic autocracy. They can hold seats in the Takht, capped at 40 percent of the seats, so Sikh jathas always hold a 60 percent majority there. The cap is not religious discrimination in membership: any jatha can form around any belief, including an atheist or anarchist one. (This is the most contested design choice in the proposal, and Khalistan's critics will press hardest on it. It would need to be defended openly as a safeguard for the Sikh character of the state, balanced by the commission and emergency powers described below.)

The Commission

The rights of minorities and non-Sikhs are protected by a body that sits outside the government: the Commission. It consists of 100 randomly selected citizens, both professionals and non-professionals, whose duty is to audit the books and root out corruption. Like a jury, they convene once a year to review the Sarbat Khalsa and weed out unlawful behavior. To protect them from tampering, members are anonymous and chosen anew each year.

Emergency Corruption Procedure

If the Sikh branches of government are acting unscrupulously, the non-Sikh members of the Takht and the Commission can act together. They have two courses.

First, they can take their case to the Supreme Jathedar or the Panj Pyare. If either agrees, the Senate and Takht jathas are dissolved and new jathas and jathedars must be installed.

If neither agrees, the second option is to dissolve the Takht in the same manner while keeping the Senate intact. In that case the whole theocratic branch must be replaced, including the Panj Pyare, the Supreme Jathedar, and the jathedars of the five Takhts. Anyone found to have acted unlawfully would be charged and tried in the judicial system. Keeping the Senate in place creates a deliberate rift between the Senate and the theocracy. With the theocracy facing dissolution, the Senate would have every reason to call out genuine corruption and help save it.

Flexibility

This system can also adapt to circumstances. Economies move in boom-and-bust cycles, and a political system should be able to move with them. The whole structure can rotate like a wheel according to the country's needs, with the Senate leading. It can propose changes to fiscal policy or responses to existential threats, and it can push for extreme measures, from dramatic liberalization to intense conservatism, depending on what the people need.

Senate and Takht members must understand that serving as a jathedar is *seva*, so these positions are unpaid. Only ministers are paid, because they perform the day-to-day work of running the country. Jathedars carry heavy responsibilities and are bound by many restrictions. The Sarbat Khalsa meets every two weeks in Amritsar, and its members live in homes around Harmandir Sahib, closest to the heart of Sikh life. Jathedars are expected to take part in the religious ceremonies of all groups.

This system rests on organization, compassion, and cooperation. It does not assume Sikhs are infallible. It accepts that human beings are flawed and tries to compensate with a flexible, layered system built on high principles.

The Supreme Jathedar

The Supreme Jathedar is not a figurehead. The office can replace the jathedar of any jatha but cannot ban a jatha, which requires a majority vote of the house the jatha belongs to. The Supreme Jathedar resolves religious disputes, issues proclamations against other countries, and must be present for any Sarbat Khalsa meeting to be valid, overseeing it and keeping decorum among the parties.

The Prime Minister is the chief diplomat and spends most time dealing with other nations. The office has no special control over government except over the other ministers, acting more as a project manager who

keeps their work on track. Any two groups that work together can accomplish a great deal. Members may switch jathas only once a year.

The State Level

At the regional level, the system needs flexibility to address local issues. Pure democracy has a further weakness at this level: office-holders leverage their positions for connections, whether by who they know or who knows them. To counter this, I propose a two-part system of appointed ministers who work anonymously and elected officials who hold no real power.

The anonymous ministers are handpicked by the Sarbat Khalsa on merit, with heavy weight on professional experience and education. They shadow the national ministries: for example, every region would have a transportation minister who reports to the national transportation minister. The Sarbat Khalsa can add or remove positions as needed.

Provincial Panj

In each locality, a group of five is elected. They may campaign but hold no real power. Their role is to check their regional ministers, lodge complaints, and tell the government what the people consider most pressing. Everyone who wants a place appears on the ballot, and the five with the most votes are elected. If all five vote to veto a minister's decision, it is vetoed.

A pure democracy can put someone with no economic training into the finance ministry on the strength of a popularity contest. Here, ministers are anonymous, so they cannot leverage connections, and the elected five can challenge their moves. One side can do certain things and not others, and the other side fills the gap.

The Legal Assembly

The second institution in each state is a legal assembly of lawyers who draft legislation they believe benefits their state, shaped by the ministers, the Provincial Panj, and the will of the people. Each proposal is signed by all state-level authorities and sent to the Sarbat Khalsa for review and vote. A state cannot simply pass what it wants, because every law affects the whole country. A law that sends more transportation funding to one state, for example, could drain resources from another that needs them more.

The great strengths of a Sikh state are that it is lean and resistant to corruption. But no one should be naïve about human nature, which is why the government deliberately includes obstacles and barriers. Villages can keep their traditional local governance through the sarpanch and panchayat, and cities would have councils that are half elected and half appointed. The number of positions at each level would be decided by the Sarbat Khalsa, considering population, land, and other factors. The numbers here are theoretical.

4. Economic Structure

The classic question is how Khalistan would be self-sufficient. It is not a serious obstacle. South Asia has examples of both financial disasters and economic miracles, and we know what works and what doesn't. Many countries have gone from poverty to booming economies. The best model is the East Asian "tiger" development model, which has been widely studied. In short, it calls for government support of three sectors in a specific order: agriculture, then industry, then finance.

Agriculture

Punjab already has the first sector. Its land is among the five most fertile on earth, and its agriculture compares well with that of South Korea, which used this model. Agriculture is developed first, not at industrial scale but at "gardening" scale. Smaller plots tend to produce greater yields, and by emphasizing yield over profit at the start, a country can scale up later. Feeding the population and becoming productive lays the groundwork for industrialization. Small landowning farmers are generally more productive than tenants or large-scale agribusiness, and the evidence for this is strong.

Punjab has long been treated as India's grain basket, with little industry of its own. Many Sikh farmers saw the 2020 farm laws as undermining the profits that sustain them, and the protests that followed reflected the fear that a system built for high yields at low margins would leave farmers worse off. A sovereign Punjab would put agricultural policy in the hands of those who farm the land, and a strong agricultural base leads naturally into industry.

Industry and Manufacturing

The principle is simple: firms learn to make better goods, export them, and compete globally. The government weeds out poor performers to reward good ones. Countries typically start with exports like textiles and move up to complex manufacturing such as cars. Industrial growth lifts people out of poverty by creating jobs, and it offers an alternative to the thousands of Punjabis who emigrate each year for lack of opportunity.

Finance and Banking

The financial sector comes third, using the assets and growth created by the first two. Banking, taxation, and other government levers direct capital where it is needed. The tiger model has been studied closely, and the data show what works and what does not. Khalistan needs no reinvention of the wheel, only discipline and intelligent cooperation from government.

Tourism

I would add one more pillar: making Punjab a tourism hub for South Asia. Beautiful places attract visitors, and visitors spend money. The Gurus constantly founded cities and made them centers of community and beauty,

and that legacy can be applied at scale through strong building and maintenance standards and a commitment to beauty.

Sikhs have little reason to worry about prosperity. Sikhs are established in every sector worldwide, in blue-collar and white-collar work and in government. This vision would coalesce those skills in service of a Sikh state. The economic structure is not tied to one ideology, only to an end goal: degh for all. The Khalsa would be the economic soldiers carrying those without to the land of those with. The guiding rule is Guru Nanak's *kirat karo*: an honest economy that does not cheat its workers, and a land of opportunity where no one must give up dignity or morality for a better life.

5. Phase 1: Room Service

****Housekeeping.**** The first phase is the immediate setup of the state and requires urgent action on the most pressing internal and external problems.

External. Security comes first: territorial integrity and defense. The army would rest on mandatory military service, which follows both the Khalsa tradition and the standards of international statecraft, since hostile actors may lurk at the borders. This could be a period of fluid territory, with borders growing or shrinking. Energy security comes second. A new country needs ample energy to begin developing, and securing short-term supply by any workable means is vital, along with access to seaports and overland routes for goods. A Khalistan currency would be issued, gradually replacing foreign currencies.

Internal. The most pressing task is organizing the government and drafting a founding document, a constitution or charter, agreed upon by the whole Sarbat Khalsa so that it is not the product of one mind. I would strongly favor a provision for the legal ability to own firearms without heavy obstruction, as in America. I would also include strong free-speech protections, modeled on those of the West but with an amendment: Khalistan, as a dharmic state, respects all religions and paths, and violence or blasphemy against religious places or objects is not acceptable. Discriminating against or putting down other religions would be grounds for legal action.

Infrastructure would be the first great public project, putting a large part of the population to work quickly with high-speed rail, bridges, and other projects. The last step of this phase is to open the borders in both directions. Anyone who wishes to come may come, and any Muslim, Hindu, or Sikh who wishes to leave is welcome to be the master of their own destiny.

6. Phase 2: The First Brick

With the urgent issues dealt with and a calmer atmosphere established, the second phase lays the foundations for industry, institutions, and new roots. New cities would be built. Khalistan would compete for foreign investment and strike trade agreements with allies and neighbors. Foreign policy would brand Khalistan as a protector of the meek, with embassies and ambassadors around the world.

This is also the aesthetic phase of nation-building: the nation's iconography and a cohesive architecture, with parliaments, courts, and civic buildings that uphold the dignity of the state. Every state would have its own civic buildings to serve the people, and the city would become the stronghold of society.

The Gurdwara would serve as it traditionally did, as a center of education. Education would be a hallmark of Khalistan, producing leading scholars, thinkers, innovators, and teachers. The Gurdwara network would educate the poor, especially in rural areas, where regular schools are out of reach. Gianis would be trained not only in dharmic knowledge but also in English, math, history, and science, and the education would be open to all children of all backgrounds and certified to allow them to progress to higher learning. The state would encourage the diaspora to return to its ancestral homeland, strengthening ties between the community abroad and at home.

The goal would be peace and safety and not merely law and order, with safety for minorities and women a first priority, pursued through restructured urban centers and police forces. The watchword of this phase is *standards*: high standards that come from the Khalsa and that government and its institutions must meet. Sanitation industries would clean the nation as part of its beautification, and certain cities would be designated havens. Amritsar would finally receive its status as a holy city, with the decorum that goes with it. The Anandpur Sahib Resolution would be fulfilled as far as possible, though it was written for a Punjab within India and would need adapting. The Khalsa is the line of kings, and a country should be fit for kings to dwell in.

7. Phase 3: Open House

In the third phase, the state shows itself on the world stage. The house is in order, and Sikhs can take an active role internationally. A country that has cleaned up and stabilized itself can lend its ability and help to allies and to the unfortunate of the world. At home, there is never a view that the pinnacle has been reached, only a lived commitment to constant improvement, like *kaizen*.

Great social projects need not be monumental buildings or tall statues. They can be care for the destitute. Through the Gurdwara network and its resources, the disabled and the poor would be helped and reintegrated into society with dignity. The press would be free to report the truth without state pressure to produce propaganda, and citizens would have the right to challenge misinformation and deceit in journalism. Transparency in this phase keeps the nation honest for the long term. It is also the

phase in which partnerships with regional countries become paramount, extending a helping hand and gaining the benefits of working together as human beings.

8. The Codex of Cities

The Kartarpur Protocol

The city is central to Sikh tradition: every Guru founded and nurtured cities for the growth of the panth. Cities let people live in large communities with access to standardized services. A Sikh city begins with a central gurdwara, much as the Acropolis anchored Athens. Both stand in a strategic central location, and urban planning radiates from that center, with the whole city shaped toward it.

The specific buildings and their number are too detailed to settle here, but some principles matter. A beautiful city depends on standards and cohesion. It cannot be a scatter of randomly placed buildings in clashing styles. It must flow and connect to create harmony. Planning must create open places where people gather, such as plazas and squares, and there is a great deal to borrow from many nations and periods of history. We have enough evidence to know what yields good living and what makes for a depressing life. The principle is public opulence for all to enjoy over private opulence for the few. Standards and practices, from materials to aesthetics to overall planning, will be the dogma for building cities that last for millennia.